

CHI Stitch 'n B*tch, A Feminist HCI Meetup

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Abstract

This meetup invites feminist researchers and allies to gather for a relaxed textile crafting session (for all levels of expertise, including complete beginners) alongside informal discussion of our research, experiences, and visions for community-building in HCI. Building on a tradition of grassroots feminist CHI gatherings named #CHIiversity since 2017—including zine-making, lunch meetups, curating lists of feminist and social justice-oriented papers published at CHI each year, and online programs during the pandemic, this

session provides a safe and creative space to connect in times of increasing academic precarity and censorship. The format facilitates networking across institutions, disciplines, and career stages, while fostering dialogue that affirms feminist ideas as central to HCI. By offering an explicitly critical feminist environment as part of the CHI program, this meetup not only supports immediate exchange and connection, but also strengthens the long-term continuity of feminist community within CHI.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; **Interaction design**.

Keywords

feminist hci, craft, embroidery, critical making, inclusive design

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1 Introduction & Meetup description

In times of global crisis, when scholarly censorship is on the rise [53] and competitive academic structures continue to marginalize feminist, queer, social-justice, and critical approaches [6, 35], it is vital that CHI provides space for scholars to gather in ways that value safety and community. This meetup offers just such a space, a *'stitch 'n bitch'* session: a relaxed, hands-on embroidery crafting session¹ where feminist researchers and allies can share their interests, find solidarity in common struggles, discuss research, and imagine ways to strengthen and sustain our community both within CHI, and beyond.

The topic is timely and widely appealing, as feminist HCI has moved from the margins to become central to the field, shaping debates on ethics, design, and critique. Since Bardzell's foundational 2010 paper, positioning feminism as a natural ally to interaction design [7, 16], feminist HCI has expanded into a wide range of domains. Researchers have applied feminist commitments in contexts such as food technologies [43], intimate, reproductive, and menopausal technologies [22, 23, 29, 39, 45, 47, 49, 66], health care pathways [44, 58], technologies addressing gender-based violence and support [1, 3, 63], anti-fat bias [55, 56], data practices [19, 41, 42, 61], biodesign and ecological issues [13, 14, 20, 64], and making and unmaking practices [9, 10, 21, 57], as well as emerging technology discourses [51], among others. Together, these works highlight how feminist HCI has grown into a sustained mode of practice, critique, and community-building, a trajectory this meetup seeks to continue.

This meetup builds on a long-standing tradition of grassroots feminist gatherings at CHI: *fempower.tech's CHIiversity campaigns* [60], which have run yearly since 2017², and include lunch meetups, zine-making and crafting workshops³, and pandemic-era online programming that sustained our community across distances. These gatherings have been well attended (>80 attendees at CHI 2025) and highly appreciated, demonstrating both the feasibility of the proposed format and its value to the conference.

The organizing team draws on extensive experience in feminist HCI initiatives, ensuring that we can host an inclusive, generative, and well-facilitated event. With organizers spanning different career stages from early PhD researchers to postdoctoral fellows, supported by senior scholars, we are well-positioned to welcome newcomers to CHI by offering peer support and mentorship, while also strengthening networks across the breadth of feminist HCI. Several of us have co-organized informal feminist meetups at CHI and other venues over the past years, ensuring continuity with

the feminist community's long-standing grassroots presence at the conference. As organizers, we also bring extensive experience hosting workshops, SIGs, and craft-based gatherings across major HCI venues. Collectively, we have co-organized workshops at CHI [28, 33, 46, 54, 57, 64, 72], DIS [30, 34, 70], CSCW [31, 38, 40], C&C [69, 71], TEI [8, 11, 12, 15, 68], and Aarhus [2, 67], among others [26, 36].

Our goal is not only to provide a safe(er), low-barrier, and joyful space at CHI2026, but also to continue developing a visible, long-term community of feminist researchers within SIGCHI⁴. By convening a large and diverse body of participants, this meetup acknowledges and affirms that feminist ideas are no longer fringe but foundational. CHI offers the opportunity to recognize, give visibility, and support these gatherings that originated as grassroots campaigns and can become an official and enduring part of the program, while still being shaped by the feminist HCI community.

1.1 Why a 'Stitch 'n B*tch'?

In Middle English, the word "gossip" meant "friend", and it was not until later that the word became negative and derogatory, used to refer to dismissed and trivial malicious chatter [27]. However, gossip has historically served as a tool for women and minorities excluded from formal and institutional channels of communication to circulate knowledge and articulate critiques that could not be voiced openly. Rather than reinforcing social hierarchies and power differences, gossip often facilitated solidarity and the preservation of marginalized forms of knowledge. Likewise, complaint (which we metaphorize as 'bitching'), often derogatorily attributed to feminists who speak out about a problem, can be an important and generative lens to learn about power. For feminist scholars like Sara Ahmed, complaint is not only about individual dissatisfaction, but about collective survival and resistance: it becomes a way of naming systemic injustices, creating new feminist archives of institutional failure, but also reimagining more just worlds [4, 5].

In addition, textiles occupy a central place in feminist HCI as both material practice [59], a medium for political protest and expression [67], and a subject of inquiry due to the often dismissed link between textiles and computation [52, 61, 62]. Long associated with domestic labor and women's work, textile production has often been devalued under patriarchal and capitalist systems, cast aside, and separated from technical or intellectual work [48]. Yet, as many HCI and media scholars have pointed out, early computation borrowed much of its structures from punchcards used in weaving looms [50]. Yet, computing has often been celebrated as a masculine-coded field of innovation. Practices like weaving, knitting, sewing, and embroidery have also served as modes of storytelling and political expression, from early embroidered cloths and tapestries encoding women's experiences, to suffragette banners and contemporary fiber art activism (e.g., [17, 18, 24, 25, 32, 37, 65]). Within this genealogy, textiles emerge not as a passive or apolitical craft, but as a historically significant medium through which feminists have formed gatherings: here enters the *stitch 'n bitch*.

For our meetup, we propose a *stitch 'n bitch* (a concept widely used in the craft community) as a way to build on the feminist legacy of gossip, complaint, and textiles, and because crafting offers a way

¹Or – bring your own knitting, crochet, weaving, spinning, basketry or creative materials.

²#CHIiversity campaigns: 2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2025

³often staged in a "guerrilla" style by appropriating coffee break spaces and other informal venues

⁴Special Interest Group on Computer-Human Interaction (<https://sigchi.org>)

of being together that is low-stakes, tactile, hands-on, and inclusive. It gives participants something to do with their hands, without any expectation to prove academic expertise—just come as you are, pick up the materials we provide, and make something together. The making can also extend beyond the meetup, accompanying attendees into conference sessions or quiet moments.

2 Meetup goals

Building on the feminist practices of gossip, complaint, and craft outlined above, our specific goals are:

- **Create a safe and welcoming space:** centering feminist-identifying researchers, including people of color, queer, trans, and disabled scholars, with particular support for students and early-career researchers. We aim to offer refuge from the often overwhelming conference environment, promoting researcher wellbeing and inviting the community to slow down through informal connection and craft. Discrimination or hate will not be tolerated.
- **Reclaim gossip and complaint as feminist practices:** recognizing them as important modes of critique, solidarity, and collective knowledge-making that expose and resist academic and institutional injustices.
- **Engage in textile crafting as a tool for care and feminist expression:** offering a low-stakes, hands-on activity that supports wellbeing, relaxation, and mutual care, while also building on the lineage of textiles as feminist storytelling, protest, and subtle conference interventions.
- **Support each other beyond venting:** while we value the importance of complaint and sharing struggles, we also aim to connect participants with concrete resources⁵ and peer advice around issues like academic and workplace oppression, precarious employment, and student–supervisor power dynamics.
- **Sustain the community beyond CHI:** building on our existing informal networks, we will establish more lasting forms of connection (e.g., a website, Instagram, Signal, or Discord group) that share resources, document outcomes (e.g., badge add-ons, craft-based interventions), and provide an entry point for new members at future conferences. In this way, the meetup becomes part of a broader trajectory of feminist HCI community-building and ensures continuity across conferences rather than remaining a single event.

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⁵Such as SIGCHI CARES <https://sigchi.org/about/sigchi-cares/>

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